

EPISODE 5 (SESSION 1)

A Misplaced Curse

PRIMARY TEXT: GENESIS 9

In Genesis 1 and 2, we are given an invitation to stop creating.
In Genesis 9, we are given an invitation to stop destroying.
What will we choose to do with this invitation?

We live in a time where division is commonplace. We feel anger or hurt by others and our response is one of vitriol. Vengeance. For whatever reason, warranted or not, we easily create lists of those who rub us the wrong way, whom we simply dislike, or those we hate. Yet, even when our pain is well deserved, what happens when we let this need to seek vengeance rule us? Usually, nothing good. It eats away at our own souls and can have long lasting ramifications on ourselves, those within our own circles, and anyone standing nearby.

What happens when we let this need to seek vengeance rule us?

In Genesis 9, Noah has been greatly, and possibly quite painfully, wronged. In his rage he seeks to play God in the story. Noah curses not just the one who wronged him, but his son, his descendants, an entire group of people. As Reed points out, *God* didn't even curse Adam and Eve, the wrongdoers, earlier in Genesis, but Noah takes a curse and casts it on a human being—and not even the one who wronged him!

How often do we seek to play God rather than seek Him first?

In doing so, Noah creates an ongoing enemy for his own people—a division that blurs the lens meant to help him see others the way God sees them. Noah's rage-driven decision to curse the son of the one who wronged him created a future of tragedies he couldn't even begin to imagine. How often do we seek to play God rather than seek Him first? To enact vengeance on those who hurt us or our loved ones as if we think God doesn't see our pain? Because God surely does hear our cries.

There's so much more to come in this story about God's justice, so don't think that in not seeking vengeance the other option is to be okay with being hurt or taken advantage of—it's not supposed to be just "forgive and forget." Let yourself heal, and trust the Story—that God is enough, loves you enough, and knows when to say enough.

Noah needed to learn when to trust instead of destroy. He lived another 350 years stewing in bitterness and even regret of what his decision to not trust had truly done to himself and the rest of the world.

Looking at this story and the lessons behind the Midrash reminds us that not one of us is clean. Not one of us is perfect. We have the capacity to do great wrong, yet also incredibly great good.

What kind of person will you choose to be?

We can choose vengeance and division and violence, or we can choose to do the next right thing. To stop the cycle of vengeance by trusting the Story to God. Again, this doesn't mean sit and do nothing, waiting for God to "act" (we'll get there!), but it means looking at the practices God modeled for us and has been trying to teach us since the beginning.

God modeled for Adam and Eve how to stop creating. He rested.

When they didn't, he met them where they were at, clothed them, and gave them the tools to move on.

God modeled for Noah how to stop destroying. He pointed the bow in the clouds toward the heavens, not toward the creation He loved.

God is giving us an invitation to know when to stop creating. To know when to stop destroying. To trust the Story.

**We have the capacity
to do great wrong, yet
also incredibly great
good.**

PRAYER

*God,
Help us to stop the cycle of vengeance that
roars at the tip of our tongue, the ends of our fingers,
eating away at our heart.
Teach us to forgive—
our words full of life, our hands held open
our hearts bearing peace.
Teach us to love our friends and enemies
all created in your image.
Amen.*

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 5

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

What piece of Genesis 9 could you meditate over and memorize this week? What could you carry with you? (Check out our YouVersion Reading Plans to help guide you.)



COMMUNITY

What relationships do you have that remind you to not seek vengeance but goodness? Who surrounds you and sits with you when you are hurting or grieving and reminds you that you are good, God is good, and you can trust Him?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who would be impacted by the reminder of God's promise to stop destroying and the cycle of vengeance? Who needs to hear that just like our God is different, we should be too? How do you model this with your actions; not just words?



WRESTLING

What questions do you have after this lesson? About Midrash in general? The one in this episode in particular? Remember, questions are good! Questions were/are the point. What are you still wrestling with, and why? Don't forget to try and do this in community!



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*True success is developing intimacy with God, and **recognizing what God may be trying to teach you can help you create it.** As you enter into space with God, what anger or vengeance may you need to give to Him? What spaces do you have, or could you create, for God to enter into to help you remember this and challenge you to stop the cycle of vengeance? Is this sacred devotional time, small groups, prayer, other spiritual disciplines?*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

*We believe young adults are shaping the future of this world, yet so many of them have experienced or seen more vengeance than they have God's love and commitment to stop destroying. **How can you show young people that God is inviting them into a future of goodness and is not waiting to cast vengeance?** How could you model the invitation to stop creating and/or stop destroying for them?*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*Do you see those at your "work" in the goodness God sees them in or as the "other" who will get what's coming to them? Do we seek vengeance when things go wrong in our workplace, or do we seek to end the cycle of vengeance, anger, bitterness? How we bring life to others is something God says is central to our presence in the world—and believing that it's not our job to play God and cast vengeance is part of that. The way we manage employees and interact with customers or coworkers says a lot about the God we believe in and what that God believes about humanity. **The work we do every day is sacred. It matters—and so does how we seek to heal and maintain relationships within it.***